privilege of a private education because of scholarships that recognized my talent, but there was no silver spoon in our family's cutlery drawer.

Some of the lads in the Essex Colts teams were more worldly, and maybe spent a little more time in front of the mirror than I was used to. I was fortunate to grow up in a first-team dressing room in which the standards were set by the likes of Ronnie Irani and Darren Gough. They were hard, but fair, in setting definable limits.

You knew what you could, and could not, get away with. Anyone who took a liberty quickly regretted it. Ronnie was a nuts-and-bolts captain, a cricketer who made the most of himself, as an England all-rounder before chronic knee problems forced him to filter his determination through a revised role as a specialist batsman.

He would look out for younger players, like Ravi Bopara and me, if the opposition tried to bully us, and was at ease with strong characters, though he didn't exactly see eye to eye with Nasser Hussain, who gave me a three-week masterclass at the end of his career. I opened with him in his final match for Essex, scoring 51 as he marked his farewell with a trademark second-innings century.

'You're going to take my job,' he told me. Kind, slightly startling words, but his example had as great an impact. Here was a former England captain who had played in ninety-six Tests, giving his all when others would have coasted into retirement. I watched, entranced, as he worried away at his batting grip and twiddled nervously. He was seeking answers, searching for secrets until the end. It was the first manifestation of the survival gene that characterizes successful sportsmen. He cared all right.

The sense of wonder, when I first stepped into that Essex dressing room with Ravi, at the age of fifteen during the school holidays, has never really left me. I'd be given a few token throwdowns at the end of nets, go through the fielding drills with the seniors, and then be allowed to sit in on the team meeting. I was being introduced gently to the trade.

Any airs or graces were fair game. I slaughtered James Foster for walking past me without a word when I went to see him play for the first team at Colchester, but knew he was in his own little world, and we were forming lifelong bonds. The democracy of cricket unites people who, outside the game, might have little in common.

I consider Ben Stokes one of my better mates. He's from a completely different background to me, and from the other end of the country, but we